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AUSPICIOUS START CM Naveen Patnaik, Sri Dibya Singha Deb and V.K. Pandian inaugurating the corridor

PATNAIK MAY BE THE ONLY OPPOSITION LEADER TO HAVE UPSTAGED PRIME MINISTER NARENDRA MODI IN THE EYES OF THE HINDU ELECTORATE, AT LEAST IN ODISHA

Jayant Kumar Sarangi, the Puri MLA who also represents the saffron camp, has been vocal against the project as well. He complains that one of the oldest libraries in Puri, the Raghunandan Library, which housed rare manuscripts and information on the temple, has been razed. While the administration has promised to keep the books and documents safe and rebuild the library soon, Jayant is sceptical.

And even though Patnaik laid the foundation stone in November 2021, the commencement of work was delayed due to the Covid-19 pandemic. The National Monuments Authority (NMA) issued draft bylaws in the same month, prohibiting construction within a 100-metre periphery of the temple and an additional 200 metres without its approval. Although these bylaws were withdrawn after Patnaik's request in February 2022, the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) raised concerns, alleging a violation of the AMASR Act. The ASI filed an affidavit in the Odisha High Court, expressing apprehensions about potential damage to archaeological remains due to excavation without heritage impact assessment studies.

Verma says Ground Penetrating Radar Technology was used to map the vibration while digging around the temple, to monitor its impact on the structural stability of the main building or the compound wall. The Indian Institute of Technology, Gandhinagar was roped in, which provided the technology for all sorts of monitoring, he adds.

Later, the project encountered legal obstacles when two public interest litigations were simultaneously filed in the Supreme Court seeking a stay on the project. Nevertheless, the apex court rejected both pleas and imposed a fine of Rs 1 lakh on the petitioners for "frivolous litigation". All roadblocks were cleared in September 2022, after the NMA's go-ahead for the construction.

'POLITICS' OF RELIGION

The timing of the inauguration has not gone unnoticed. With Prime Minister Narendra Modi riding an unprecedented wave of public attention in the build-up to the consecration of Balak Ram in Ayodhya, Patnaik may be the only opposition leader to have upstaged the PM in the eyes of the Hindu electorate—at least in Odisha. According to experts, the timing of the inauguration is integral to the Biju Janata Dal's attempt to negate the BJP's Hindutva push ahead of this year's election. While BJD leaders refute any suggestion that the Jagannath Temple redevelopment project is aimed at cementing the party's position in Odisha, which goes to assembly polls simultaneously with the parliamentary election, sources say the initiative was taken up after the 2019 assembly and Lok Sabha polls. The BJD had won 112 of the 147 assembly seats and the BJP improved on its previous tally by 13 to wrest 23 seats. The parliamentary polls saw the BJD tally slide to 12, from 20 in 2014, against the BJP winning eight seats, seven more than the previous time. The verdict in Puri was divided: the Lok Sabha seat went to the BJD's Pinaki Misra while the BJP's Jayanta Kumar Sarangi won the assembly seat.

Samir Ranjan Dash, the BJD's MLA from Nimapara, which falls under the Puri Lok Sabha seat, says: "Jagannath is everyone's lord. Even Muslims worship him. The BJP is the product of the RSS (Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh) and they practise the politics of Hindutva. Naveen Patnaik and the BJD are flag-bearers of secularism." Bureaucrat-turned-politician Pandian on January 20 said that Patnaik was willing to forgo his government if that was the cost of completing the heritage corridor. The impact of the redevelopment could be understood by what the servitors of the temple told the chief minister in December last year—that he will be remembered like the 12th century King Indradyumna, who is credited with constructing the main temple.

Seated on a newly constructed bench along the Parikrama Path, 56-year-old Sunil Sarkar from Nadia, West Bengal, recites Jagannath's Pranam Mantra with folded hands. When asked about his opinion on the renovated temple compound, Sarkar raises his hands to his forehead and softly remarks, "Everything is His will!" ■